FREE GUIDE

The AME Canada Roadmap

How to become an Aircraft Maintenance Engineer in Canada — and how to actually get started

Written by Dilpreet

Aircraft maintenance apprentice · Sharing the path, not selling a shortcut

SECTION 1

Welcome — Why I Made This

Hi, I'm Dilpreet.

I came to Canada in 2022. I completed an 18-month aircraft maintenance program at Centennial College, and I'm now working as an apprentice, building the experience and logbook entries I need to earn my AME licence.

I'm still on this path. I haven't finished it. That's exactly why I'm writing this.

After one of my Instagram Reels reached over 250,000 people, my inbox filled with the same questions over and over: *How do I become an AME? What education do I need? Can you refer me? Where do I even start?*

> Let me answer the referral one first, clearly: **I'm not a recruiter, and I can't refer anyone into my company.** What I can do is share what I've actually learned — the path as I've experienced it, what worked, what I got wrong, and what I wish someone had told me in 2022.

That's what this roadmap is. Not official guidance. Not a shortcut. Just an honest map from someone a few steps ahead of you.

How to use this: read it start to finish once, then come back to the sections you need. The last section gives you a 30-day plan so this doesn't become one more thing you read and forget.

SECTION 2

What Is an AME?

An **Aircraft Maintenance Engineer (AME)** is a licensed professional responsible for maintaining, inspecting, and repairing aircraft — and critically, for **signing the maintenance release** that certifies an aircraft is airworthy.

That signature is the heart of the job. When an AME signs, they are personally certifying that the work meets standard and the aircraft is safe to fly. It's a licensed trade for the same reason medicine is licensed: the consequences of getting it wrong are severe.

What the day-to-day actually looks like

- Scheduled inspections and servicing
- Troubleshooting faults — often under time pressure, often at odd hours
- Component removal, repair, and installation
- Reading and following maintenance manuals precisely
- Documentation — a great deal of it, and it matters as much as the wrench work

Where AMEs work

- Airlines — scheduled and line maintenance
- MROs (Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul organizations)
- Regional and charter operators
- General aviation — flight schools, private operators
- Helicopter operators
- Manufacturing and aerospace support

What the career actually looks like: you start as an apprentice or helper working under a licensed AME. You build experience, log it, write exams, and eventually get licensed yourself. From there the path can branch — type ratings on specific aircraft, lead hand and supervisory roles, quality assurance, technical services, or training.

It's a hands-on trade with real responsibility, shift work, and a genuine skill ceiling. It is not a desk job and it's not a quick one.

SECTION 3

The Canadian AME Categories

Canada's AME licence is issued in **ratings** — you don't get a single generic "AME licence," you get a licence with specific ratings on it.

Rating	What it covers
M1	Non-turbojet aircraft with a maximum certified take-off weight below 12,566 lbs (5,700 kg) — smaller general aviation aircraft
M2	All aircraft not covered by M1 — including turbine-powered aircraft and all helicopters, regardless of weight
E	Aircraft electronic systems — communications, navigation, autoflight, instruments, electrical elements of other systems, and structural work directly associated with maintaining those systems
S	Aircraft structures — airframe structural inspection and repair

> **A useful detail:** holders of either an M1 or M2 rating also carry maintenance release privileges for all turbine-powered helicopters and SFAR 41C aeroplanes, including their variants and derivatives.

How people typically choose

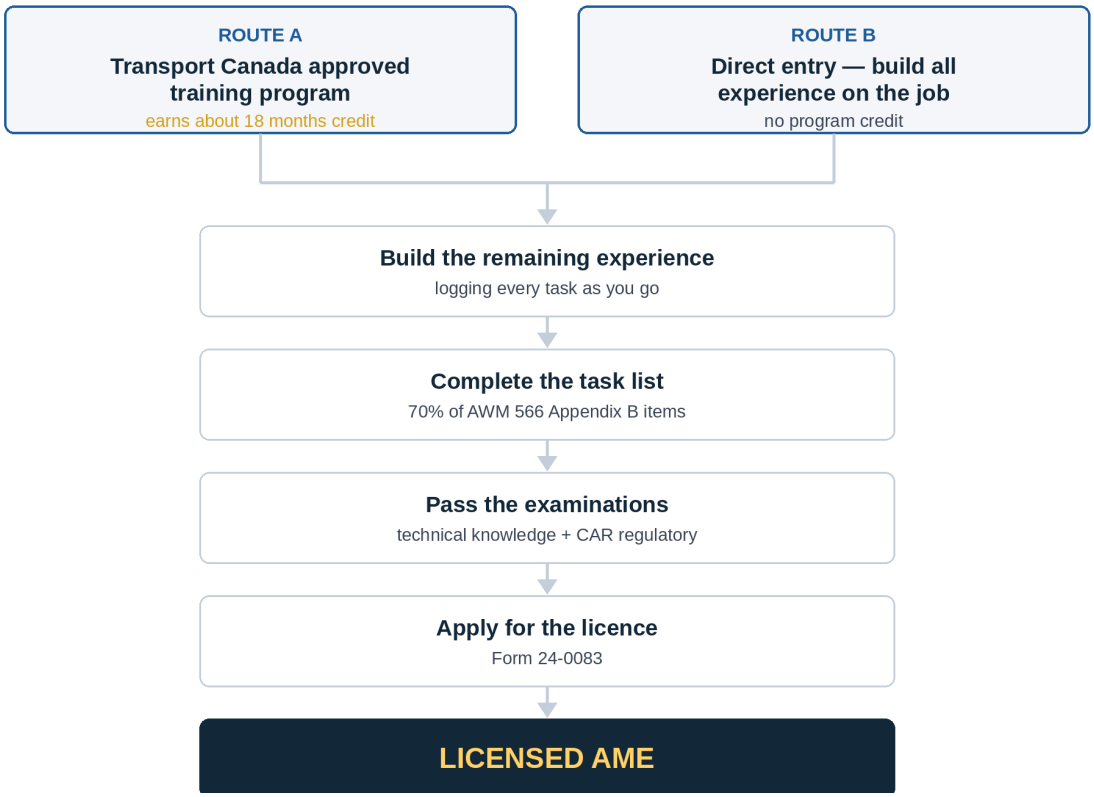
- **M** is the broadest and most common starting point — the general aircraft maintenance path
- **E** suits people drawn to electronics, avionics, and diagnostic work
- **S** suits people drawn to structural and composite repair work

You are not locked in forever. Ratings can be added later. But your choice shapes which training program you enroll in, so it's worth thinking about early rather than defaulting into one.

SECTION 4

The Canadian Pathway, Step by Step

Here is the honest shape of the path. Note that there are **two routes**, and most online advice only ever mentions one.



The experience requirement

Rating	Total experience	Specialty	On civil-registered aircraft
M or E	48 months	12 months	6 months
S	36 months	24 months	6 months

Route A — approved training program. You complete a Transport Canada–approved diploma, which earns you roughly **18 months of credit** toward that total. You still complete the remaining ~30 months as real on-the-job experience afterward.

Route B — direct entry. You skip the diploma and build all 48 (or 36) months through work. It's slower on paper and harder to break into without training, but it is a legitimate route and worth knowing exists.

The other requirements, regardless of route

- **Task list** — you must have performed at least **70% of the applicable items in Appendix B of Airworthiness Manual (AWM) 566** for your rating
- **Exams** — the technical knowledge exam(s) for your category, plus the **Regulatory Requirements (CAR)** exam. Transport Canada's official study guide is **TP 14038**
- **Minimum age** — you must be **21** for licence issuance
- **Citizenship** — you must prove citizenship of *some* country; it does **not** have to be Canadian
- **Application** — **Form 24-0083**, with original or certified documents

> **About your logbook — start it on day one.**
>
> Your experience is proven through a personal logbook (or equivalent, such as signed employer letters) recording exact dates, the work performed, and the aircraft type. This is what you eventually submit to Transport Canada.
>
> I cannot overstate this: the day you touch your first aircraft in a working capacity, start logging. People lose months of credit because they started logging late or logged sloppily.

SECTION 5

Education & Training Options

These are Transport Canada–approved programs I verified while researching this roadmap:

School	Category	Experience credit
BCIT (British Columbia)	M	18 months
Centennial College (Ontario)	M	18 months
Canadore College (Ontario)	M	18 months
Mohawk College (Ontario)	M	18 months
SAIT (Alberta)	M	18 months
Fanshawe College (Ontario)	M	18 months
RRC Polytech (Manitoba)	M	19 months

BCIT also offers separate **Category E** (approximately 68 weeks) and **Category S** (approximately 10 months) diploma programs.

Read this before you pick one

- **Verify everything directly with the school.** Program availability, duration, tuition, and admission requirements change. Do not enroll based on this table, a blog post, or a Reddit thread — confirm on the institution's own website or with their admissions office.
- **Credit is often conditional.** SAIT, for example, requires 95% attendance and minimum 70% in each course to grant the 18-month credit. Showing up and passing is not automatically enough. Check the conditions at your school.
- **Admission requirements vary.** Canadore, for instance, requires OSSD or equivalent with Grade 12 English and Grade 12 Math. BCIT requires demonstrated English proficiency. Others differ.

> **A note on education terminology:** this roadmap uses Canadian terms — "Grade 12" or "high school completion." If you're coming from India, that generally corresponds to completing +2 / Class 12. But do **not** assume that completing +2 automatically qualifies you for every AME program. Each institution sets its own admission requirements, including subject prerequisites and English proficiency. Check them individually.

SECTION 6

A Note for International Students

This section matters, and I want to be careful with it.

Two separate systems. Your AME licence and your immigration status are governed by two completely different authorities, and confusing them causes real problems:

- **Transport Canada** decides licensing. As noted, the licence requires proof of citizenship of *any* country — it does not require Canadian citizenship.
- **IRCC (Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada)** decides who is legally allowed to work in Canada. That's a separate question with separate rules.

> **You do not need the licence to start working.** This surprises a lot of people. You can work as an **apprentice or helper** under the supervision of a licensed AME while building the experience toward your own licence. The licence is the destination, not the entry ticket.

But you do need valid work authorization for that apprentice role. That could be a Post-Graduation Work Permit, or another type of work permit, or permanent residence — it depends entirely on your situation. Eligibility rules for these change, and they changed meaningfully as recently as this year.

So here's my honest position: I am not an immigration consultant and I will not guess at your eligibility. Confirm your specific situation directly at canada.ca / IRCC, or with a licensed immigration professional. Nothing in this roadmap should be treated as immigration advice, and no program — at any school — guarantees a work permit, permanent residence, or employment.

SECTION 7

Getting Your First Aviation Experience

The hardest part isn't the exams. It's getting through the door the first time.

Realistic entry points

- **Apprentice / helper roles** at maintenance organizations — the most direct route
- **MROs** — often more open to inexperienced candidates than airlines
- **Regional and charter operators** — smaller teams, more willing to train
- **General aviation** — flight schools and small operators, where you'll touch a wide variety of work
- **Helicopter operators** — a distinct and often underserved corner of the industry

> **A tactic that works, and that I've watched work:** apply for *any* legitimate job inside an airport — ramp, ground handling, cargo, fuelling, customer service. Some people I studied with got airport jobs during their program and used them as a foot in the door.
>
> Why this works: you're physically inside the environment. You meet people. You hear about openings before they're posted. You learn how an airport actually operates. It's not an AME job and I won't pretend it is — but it's proximity, and proximity in this industry compounds.

One caution: no specific route guarantees employment. What I'm describing is how people commonly get in, not a formula that always produces a job.

SECTION 8

Finding Your First Aviation Job

Where to look

- **Employer career pages** — check these directly and regularly; many roles never reach the big boards
- **LinkedIn** — more on this in the next section, because it's not just a job board
- **Indeed** — volume, but real postings
- **Aviation-specific job boards**
- **Direct outreach** — emailing maintenance managers at organizations you'd like to work for
- **Networking** — instructors, classmates, anyone already inside the industry

Job titles to search for: Apprentice Aircraft Maintenance Engineer, Aircraft Maintenance Apprentice, Aircraft Maintenance Helper, Aviation Maintenance Technician, AME Apprentice. The same job wears different titles at different companies — search broadly.

How to approach employers when you have limited experience

- Be specific about where you are: your program, your credit toward the licence, your category
- Be clear about what you're asking for — an apprentice or entry-level role, not a licensed position
- Keep it short. Maintenance managers are busy people who read email between tasks
- Follow up once, about 5–7 days later. Once. Not four times

SECTION 9

How to Stand Out in a Competitive Market

This is the section I most wish someone had given me in 2022.

> Here's the uncomfortable truth: **everyone graduating from your program has the same diploma you do.** Same courses, same credit, same certificate. On paper, you are interchangeable with your entire graduating class. Technical skill gets you considered. It does not get you chosen.

What separates people is the stuff nobody tests you on.

Build your LinkedIn — and build it early. Not a resume mirror. A real profile: a clear headline saying what you are and what you're working toward, your program, your category, what you're looking for. Then actually use it — follow aviation companies, engage with people in the industry, connect with classmates and instructors. Recruiters and hiring managers genuinely look here.

Soft skills carry more weight than people expect

- **Communication** — including spoken English confidence. You'll be explaining faults, reading back instructions, and writing documentation that other people's safety depends on
- **Problem-solving** — troubleshooting is the job. Not following steps; figuring out what's actually wrong
- **Reliability** — showing up, on time, consistently. In an industry built on trust, this is not a small thing
- **Teamwork** — you're rarely working alone, and hangars are tight-knit environments

Adaptability and fresh thinking. Aviation maintenance is a traditional industry with deeply established practices — for good reasons. But there's real value in someone who can apply new tools and new thinking to old processes without being reckless about it. Being the person who improves how something is done, rather than just executing it, gets noticed.

Personal brand. How you're perceived before you ever apply. How you talk about aviation publicly, how you carry yourself, what your online presence says about you. It's quieter than the other factors but it compounds over years.

EQ and IQ both matter. Technical intelligence gets you the interview. Emotional intelligence — self-awareness, composure under pressure, taking feedback without defensiveness, reading a room — gets you the job, and matters even more for everything that comes after it.

What I got wrong

I'll be direct about my own mistakes, because they cost me time.

I didn't build my LinkedIn early enough, and I didn't start applying fast enough. I waited. I told myself I'd start properly once I felt ready.

After I graduated, I was working in a restaurant. Mind-numbing, exhausting work I didn't want to be doing, in a field I'd just spent 18 months training to leave. And I stayed there longer than I should have.

Eventually I quit. I committed fully: LinkedIn and Indeed, **two to three applications a day, sometimes five**. Head down. Focused entirely on the applying itself — not on outcomes, not on responses, not on whether any individual application went anywhere.

> **Within two months, I had an apprenticeship offer.**
>
> That's the whole lesson. Not talent, not connections. Volume, consistency, and detaching from the outcome long enough to keep going. Nail your resume, then apply relentlessly and let the numbers work.
>
> **If I could do it, you can too.**

SECTION 10

Resume & Application Basics

What belongs on an aviation-oriented resume

- **Education** — your program, institution, dates, and your Transport Canada experience credit
- **Technical training** — systems you've worked on, specific coursework that's relevant
- **Technical skills** — airframe, powerplant, electrical, hydraulics, whatever applies
- **Hands-on experience** — including non-aviation mechanical work; it counts for more than you think
- **Tools and equipment** — what you're actually proficient with
- **Certifications** — safety training, WHMIS, anything relevant
- **Transferable skills** — if you've worked in any environment demanding precision, safety awareness, or accountability, that's relevant

What employers actually care about: safety mindset, attention to detail, reliability, and whether you can follow procedure precisely. Demonstrate these through specifics, not adjectives. "Maintained 100% documentation accuracy across X" beats "detail-oriented."

Common resume mistakes

- Sending the identical resume to 50 companies
- Burying your Transport Canada credit where nobody sees it — it's one of the most relevant facts about you
- Listing responsibilities instead of what you actually did
- Typos. In an industry built on precision, a typo is a signal
- Making it long. One page, two at absolute most

SECTION 11

Interview Preparation

Before the interview

- Research the employer — what aircraft do they operate? Airline, MRO, charter, general aviation? Their fleet shapes their work
- Read the job description properly and map your experience to it
- Prepare specific examples, not general claims

What gets asked — and these are illustrative examples, not a guaranteed list:

- **Technical questions** about systems, procedures, or troubleshooting approach
- **Behavioural questions** — a time you caught a mistake, handled pressure, disagreed with someone, or worked through something difficult

How to handle limited experience. Don't apologize for it and don't inflate it. Say where you are honestly, then show what you've done with what you've had. "I haven't worked on that type yet, but here's how I approached something similar, and here's how I'd go about learning it" is a strong answer. Pretending to know something you don't is disqualifying in this industry — and rightly so, because safety depends on people admitting what they don't know.

What they're really assessing: safety mindset, whether you'll admit uncertainty rather than guess, reliability, attention to detail, communication, and willingness to learn. Much of the interview is a character assessment wearing technical clothing.

SECTION 12

Common Mistakes to Avoid

1. Confusing the Canadian AME licence with the American A&P certificate. These are different systems, different regulators, different requirements. The FAA's Airframe & Powerplant certificate is not a Canadian AME licence and doesn't convert automatically. A lot of the advice you'll find online is American — check the source before you act on it.

2. Assuming the diploma is the licence. It isn't. A Transport Canada–approved program gives you training and roughly 18 months of experience credit toward a 48-month requirement. The licence comes after the remaining experience, the task list, and the exams.

3. Starting your logbook late, or keeping it badly. Your logbook is your evidence. Incomplete entries cost you real months.

4. Choosing a program without checking where it leads. Confirm it's Transport Canada–approved, confirm the category it leads to, and confirm the conditions on the experience credit.

5. Waiting until graduation to build connections. Build your network and your LinkedIn while you're still studying. I learned this one the expensive way.

6. Applying randomly without tailoring. Volume matters — but volume of *tailored* applications. Not the same thing as spraying an identical PDF everywhere.

7. Conflating licensing with immigration status. Two different systems, two different authorities. Getting this wrong leads to expensive, avoidable decisions.

8. Treating social media as official guidance. Including this roadmap. I've researched what's here carefully, but Transport Canada is the authority — not me, and not anyone on TikTok.

9. Relying on outdated information. Requirements, programs, and policies change. Something true in 2019 may be wrong today.

SECTION 13

Your First 30 Days

Information without action is just entertainment. Here's a concrete plan.

Days 1–7 — Decide

- Finish reading this roadmap
- Choose your target category (M1 / M2 / E / S)
- Decide: approved training program, or direct-entry route
- Write the decision down. Vague intentions don't survive contact with real life

Days 8–14 — Research

- Shortlist 3–5 schools or programs
- Confirm current admission requirements with each one **directly**
- Note application deadlines
- If you're an international student, confirm your work authorization situation at IRCC

Days 15–21 — Build

- Write your resume — first draft, not a perfect one
- Set up or overhaul your LinkedIn profile
- Start a list of target employers in your region

Days 22–30 — Move

- Start applying. Track every application
- Reach out directly to at least 3 employers or industry contacts
- Follow up on anything you sent in week three
- Review what happened and set your next 30-day target

> Focus on the action, not the outcome. You control how many quality applications you send. You don't control response times. That distinction is the entire difference between people who make it in and people who quit at month two.

SECTION 14

Important Disclaimer

This roadmap is for **general educational purposes** and is based on publicly available information and my personal experience.

Requirements, programs, licensing processes, and employment conditions **change**. Always verify current requirements directly with Transport Canada, the relevant educational institution, employer, or other official authority before making decisions.

This roadmap is **not** official Transport Canada guidance and implies no affiliation with Transport Canada, any airline, employer, or training institution.

I am **not** a recruiter, an immigration consultant, or an official representative of any regulatory body. This roadmap does not provide company referrals and does not guarantee licensing, employment, or immigration outcomes.

Official sources you should use

- Transport Canada — Aircraft Maintenance Engineer licensing: tc.canada.ca
- Government of Canada / IRCC — immigration: canada.ca
- Individual institution websites — for program and admission requirements

SECTION 15

Your Next Step: The AME Career System

You now have the map. The harder part is executing it consistently over months.

That's what I built the **AME Career System** for — a Notion workspace that turns everything in this roadmap into a working system:

- **Step-by-Step AME Checklist** — the whole journey in order, checked off as you go
- **School & Program Tracker** — compare programs by category, duration, experience credit, tuition, and deadlines
- **Employer Tracker** — who you've contacted, who you haven't, when to follow up
- **Job Application Tracker** — every application with source, status, and follow-up date
- **Resume & Application Templates** — aviation resume outline, cold outreach email, follow-up message, LinkedIn note
- **Your First 30 Days Action Plan** — week by week

Get the AME Career System →

And if you never buy anything — genuinely, I hope this roadmap was useful on its own. That was the point of writing it.

Good luck out there.

— Dilpreet